

“Being the undisputed world champion is a relief. We instituted a unified chess title, I am the absolute world champion.”



wall opposite him. That shows a side of him—he wanted to excel in the game. He was always an eager player, continuously looking for different ways to win. Later on, he became calmer but his zeal to win did not dwindle. I saw Anand's determination when after narrowly missing the Grandmaster title twice, he continued with a renewed drive. More than anything, it is his style of playing that stood him in good stead. Unlike stalwarts like Kasparov who play aggressively and pressure their opponents, Anand is a player whose focus is only on his own gameplan.

It is his affable, somewhat shy and introverted nature that has made him a favourite not only with the public but also in the chess circles. I remember a small incident from my early days in chess. Some members from the Indian team at the annual Chess Olympiad wanted a picture with Kasparov, but he curtly declined. Anand, on the other hand, was never discourteous to his fans. During the 1995 matches with Kasparov, everyone prayed for Anand's victory, for they all believed that Indian chess couldn't get a better ambassador than him.

I would also give credit to his parents. During the early days players never got very good accommodation, we often used to sleep on benches. But despite such conditions his parents always toured with him. I saw Susheela aunty present at every tournament with him. It would be wrong to say that Anand played for fame or was conscious of the history he was making. I think it was simpler—he was just a boy who had grown up loving the game he played. Matching every black pawn with his white and confronting every complex move with a counter strike.

as told to Bushra Ahmed

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